SPECIFICATION OF THE CONTROLLED DESIGNATION OF ORIGIN "AJACCIO"

approved by decree no. 2011-1085 of 8 September 2011, JORF of 10/09/2011

CHAPTER I

I. – Name of the designation

Only wines meeting the specific provisions set out below may claim the controlled designation of origin "Ajaccio", initially recognised by the decree of 21 April 1971 under the name "Coteaux d'Ajaccio".

II. – Geographical denominations and complementary terms

No particular provision.

III. – Colour and types of product

The controlled designation of origin "Ajaccio" is reserved for still white, red and rosé wines.

IV. – Areas and zones in which the various operations are carried out

1° – Geographical area

The harvesting of the grapes, the vinification and the elaboration of the wines are carried out within the territory of the following communes of the Corse-du-Sud department: Afa, Ajaccio, Alata, Albitreccia, Ambiegna, Appietto, Arbori, Arro, Bastelicaccia, Calcatoggio, Canelle, Carbuccia, Cargèse, Casaglione, Casalabriva, Cauro, Coggia, Cognocoli-Monticchi, Coti-Chiavari, Cuttoli-Corticchiato, Eccica-Suarella, Grosseto-Prugna, Ocana, Peri, Piana, Pietrosella, Pila-Canale, Saint-André-d'Orcino, Sari-d'Orcino, Sarrola-Carcopino, Serra-di-Ferro, Tavaco, Valle-di-Mezzana, Vero, Vico and Villanova.

2° – Delimited parcel area

The wines come exclusively from vines situated within the delimited parcel production area as approved by the National Institute of Origin and Quality at the session of the competent national committee of 27 May 1982. The National Institute of Origin and Quality lodges with the town halls of the communes referred to in 1° the graphic documents establishing the parcel boundaries of the production area thus approved.

V. – Grape varieties

1° – Grape varieties

a) – The white wines come from the following varieties: - main variety: vermentino B (malvoisie de Corse); - accessory varieties: biancu gentile B, codivarta B, genovese B, ugni blanc B (rossola).

b) – The red and rosé wines come from the following varieties: - main varieties: barbaroux Rs (barbarossa), nielluccio N, sciaccarello N, vermentino B (malvoisie de Corse); - accessory varieties: aleatico N, carcajolo N, carignan N, cinsaut N, grenache N, morrastel N (minustello).

2° – Proportion rules on the holding

The conformity of the grape varieties is assessed, for the colour considered, over all of the parcels of the holding producing the wine of the controlled designation of origin.

a) – White wines: - the proportion of the vermentino B variety (malvoisie de Corse) is greater than or equal to 80 % of the grape varieties; - the proportion of all the biancu gentile B, codivarta B and genovese B varieties is less than or equal to 10 % of the grape varieties.

b) – Red and rosé wines: - the proportion of all the main varieties is greater than or equal to 60 % of the grape varieties; - the proportion of the sciaccarello N variety is greater than or equal to 40 % of the grape varieties; - the proportion of the carignan N variety is less than or equal to 15 % of the grape varieties; - the proportion of all the aleatico N, carcajolo N and morrastel N (minustello) varieties is less than or equal to 10 % of the grape varieties.

VI. – Management of the vineyard

1° – Training methods

a) – Planting density.
The vines present a minimum planting density of 4,000 plants per hectare. These vines may not present a spacing between rows greater than 2.80 metres and a spacing between plants within the same row less than 0.80 metre.

b) – Pruning rules.
The vines are pruned with a maximum of 12 free eyes (buds) per plant: - either by short spur pruning (trained in goblet or Royat cordon); - or by single or double Guyot pruning, with a maximum of 10 free eyes on the long cane(s).

c) – Trellising rules and foliage height.
- The training of the vine makes it possible to have 1.4 square metres of external surface of plant cover for the production of one kilogram of grapes. - For the trellised vines, the height of trellised foliage is measured between the lower limit of the foliage, established at least 0.30 metre above the ground, and the upper topping limit, established at least 0.20 metre above the upper trellising wire.

d) – Average maximum load per parcel.
The average maximum load per parcel is fixed at 7,500 kilograms per hectare. When irrigation is authorised in accordance with the provisions of Article D. 645-5 of the Rural and Maritime Fishing Code, the average maximum load per parcel of the irrigated parcels is fixed at 6,000 kilograms per hectare.

e) – Threshold for missing vines.
The percentage of dead or missing vine plants, referred to in Article D. 645-4 of the Rural and Maritime Fishing Code, is fixed at 20 %.

f) – Cultivation condition of the vine.
The parcels are managed so as to ensure a good overall cultivation condition of the vine, in particular its sanitary condition and the upkeep of its soil.

2° – Irrigation

Irrigation during the vegetative period of the vine may be authorised, in accordance with the provisions of Article D. 645-5 of the Rural and Maritime Fishing Code, only in the event of persistent drought and when the latter disturbs the good physiological development of the vine and the good ripening of the grape.

VII. – Harvest, transport and ripeness of the grapes

1° – Harvest

The wines come from grapes harvested at proper ripeness.

2° – Ripeness of the grapes

The sugar richness of the grapes and the natural alcoholic strengths by volume meet the following characteristics:

COLOUR OF THE WINES, VARIETIES	MINIMUM SUGAR RICHNESS OF THE GRAPES (grams per litre of must)	MINIMUM NATURAL ALCOHOLIC STRENGTH BY VOLUME
White and rosé wines	187	11.5 %
Red wines: cinsaut N variety	189	12 %
Red wines: other varieties	207	12 %

VIII. – Yields. – Entry into production

1° – Yield

The yield referred to in Article D. 645-7 of the Rural and Maritime Fishing Code is fixed at 45 hectolitres per hectare.

2° – Limit yield

The limit yield referred to in Article D. 645-7 of the Rural and Maritime Fishing Code is fixed at 50 hectolitres per hectare.

3° – Entry into production of young vines

The benefit of the controlled designation of origin may be granted to wines coming from: - parcels of young vines only from the 3rd year following that in the course of which planting was carried out in place before 31 July; - parcels of young vines only from the 2nd year following that in the course of which grafting in place was carried out before 31 July; - parcels of vines that have been top-grafted, at the earliest in the 2nd year following that in the course of which the top-grafting was carried out before 31 July, and once the parcels no longer contain any varieties other than those permitted for the appellation. By way of derogation, in the year following that in the course of which the top-grafting was carried out before 31 July, the varieties permitted for the appellation may represent only 80 % of the grape varieties of each parcel concerned.

IX. – Processing, elaboration, ageing, packaging, storage

1° – General provisions

The wines are vinified in accordance with local, fair and constant usages.

a) – Blending of the varieties.

- For the elaboration of the red and rosé wines, the proportion of the sciaccarello N variety, in the blends, is greater than or equal to 40 %; - for the elaboration of the white wines, the proportion of the vermentino B variety, in the blends, is greater than or equal to 80 %.

b) – Malolactic fermentation.

The malolactic fermentation is completed for the red wines. The red wines present, at the packaging stage, a maximum malic acid content of 0.4 gram per litre.

c) – Analytical standards.

- The wines present, after fermentation, a content of fermentable sugars (glucose and fructose) conforming to the following characteristics:

COLOUR OF THE WINES AND MINIMUM NATURAL ALCOHOLIC STRENGTH BY VOLUME	MAXIMUM CONTENT OF FERMENTABLE SUGARS (glucose and fructose) (grams per litre)
White, rosé and red wines whose natural alcoholic strength by volume is less than or equal to 14 %	4
White, rosé and red wines whose natural alcoholic strength by volume is greater than 14 %	5

- The wines meet, at the packaging stage, the following analytical standards:

COLOUR OF THE WINES	MAXIMUM VOLATILE ACIDITY CONTENT (milliequivalents per litre)
White and rosé wines	14
Red wines	16

d) – Oenological practices and physical treatments.

- Any enrichment operation is prohibited; - the use of wood chips is prohibited; - the use of charcoals for oenological use is prohibited; - the use of sorbic acid is prohibited.

e) – Prohibited equipment.

The use of continuous presses is prohibited.

f) – Vat capacity.
Every operator has a global vat capacity at least equal to 1.2 times the volume vinified.

g) – Good overall upkeep of the cellar (floors and walls) and equipment (hygiene).
The cellar (floors and walls) and the vinification equipment present a good general condition of upkeep.

2° – Provisions relating to packaging

For each packaged lot, the operator keeps available for the approved control body: - the information appearing in the register of handling operations referred to in Article D. 645-18 of the Rural and Maritime Fishing Code; - an analysis carried out before or after packaging. The analysis reports must be kept for a period of 6 months from the date of packaging.

3° – Provisions relating to storage

a) – The operator demonstrates a specific place for the storage of the packaged products.

b) – The storage of the packaged products is carried out in good conditions of hygiene and in a protected place.

4° – Provisions relating to the movement of products and to placing on the market for the consumer

a) – Date of placing on the market for the consumer.
The wines are placed on the market for the consumer according to the provisions of Article D. 645-17 of the Rural and Maritime Fishing Code.

b) – Period during which the wines may not move between approved warehouse keepers.
The wines may move between approved warehouse keepers at the earliest on 1 December of the year of harvest.

X. – Link with the geographical area

1° – Information on the geographical area

a) – Description of the natural factors contributing to the link

At the heart of western Corsica, between Balagne, to the north, and Sartenais, to the south, from the gulf of Porto to that of Valinco, from Cargèse to Casalabriva, the geographical area covers the territory of a set of so-called “coastal” communes. Its landscape is shaped by a succession of valleys globally oriented east/west that constitute so many micro-regions with boundaries, sometimes delicate to cross, accentuated by sometimes powerful coastal rivers. Its physical features make its originality, with dissymmetric slopes cut by long, deep and rectilinear valleys. Open onto the Mediterranean Sea, bordered by mountainous reliefs, the geographical area extends over the territory of 36 communes of the Corse-du-Sud department. At the heart of the Hercynian crystalline Corsica known as “ancient Corsica with magmatic rocks”, the geological substratum of the geographical area is dominated by granitic terrains. Between the granitic masses, a few shreds of detrital sediments rest in carboniferous and Permian basins. The soils developed on these granites are most often light, sandy-gravelly, more or less brunified on little-altered rock at shallow depth or on more or less deep grus mixed with clay. They are poor, dry, free-draining soils, with little water reserve. The geographical area is constituted of two appreciably different territories: the maritime frontage and the near hinterland. The maritime frontage, with reliefs not exceeding 150 metres to 200 metres in altitude, is marked by the penetration of the sea breezes and of the coastal fogs. The atmosphere is often humid in autumn and in winter. The thermal ranges are low. The near hinterland, formed of slopes of various orientations above the low and middle valleys, experiences a more contrasted climate. Owing to higher altitudes, which can go up to 400 metres, the precipitation is appreciably more substantial and the mesoclimates there multiply. The climate is Mediterranean, very maritime over the major part of the geographical area. The most sunny region of Corsica (2,728 hours of sun per year at Ajaccio), it is regulated by omnipresent winds, whether from the sea, from the land or from the mountain. The Tramontane and the “Libecciu” are both there dominated by the “Maestrale”. This tempered mildness makes the gulf of Ajaccio the region of early springs.

b) – Description of the human factors contributing to the link

Beyond the viticultural history common to all Corsica, Ajaccio was one of the first coastal cities founded by Rome. The Roman influence is also present in the hinterland and is at the origin of the establishment of the vineyard. The hillsides are then colonised, and the vineyard, situated at one of the highest altitudes of Corsica, is established in the situations benefiting at once from the protective effects of the reliefs and from the best exposures. The successive developments of the commune of Ajaccio influence the outlets and thus the development of the vineyard. From the primitive village towards Saint-Jean, to the establishment of a Bishopric in the 6th century, then to the rise of the 15th century, the vineyard benefits from the advantages of the most important gulf of Corsica. The desire for identification is however later than in other Corsican regions. First expressed by a request for recognition as designation of origin "vin délimité de qualité supérieure" in 1967, it is reflected, at first, by the possibility of associating the geographical denomination "Coteaux d'Ajaccio" with the name of the controlled designation of origin "Vin de Corse" or "Corse". However, the producers have always been convinced that they had a territory and a know-how capable of marking with its imprint the originality of their production. Grouped together within a defence union of the "Coteaux d'Ajaccio" affirming its orientation towards the controlled designation of origin, the producers see their efforts rewarded by the decree defining the controlled designation of origin "Coteaux d'Ajaccio" as early as 21 April 1971. Following an important work on the definition of the geographical area, going from 85 communes to 36 communes, by devoting themselves to the qualitative improvement of their production, by maintaining traditional know-how both in the establishment of the vineyard and in the preservation of the island varieties, these producers obtain the recognition of the controlled designation of origin "Ajaccio" on 3 April 1984. On this rather vast territory, about a dozen private cellars exploit 250 hectares planted with vines.

2° – Information on the quality and characteristics of the products

The wines are still dry wines. The rosé wines, essentially elaborated from the sciaccarello N and grenache N varieties, are elegant and fine wines, with fruity, spicy, even mineral notes. The red wines, very marked by the sciaccarello N variety, present a fine, brilliant robe of medium intensity that announces the elegant, fine characters of these nevertheless structured wines. The tannins are present while knowing how to make themselves discreet, leaving wide room for the intense aromas of small red fruits, blackcurrant, almond and spices. The white wines, dominated by the vermentino B variety, which must be present in a proportion of at least 80 % in the blends, express a characteristic minerality and floral distinction.

3° – Causal interactions

At the heart of a Mediterranean climate with maritime influence, benefiting from a fine sunshine and moderate rains, and reflecting the usages, the parcel area precisely delimited for the harvesting of the grapes classifies the parcels dispersed in a complex topography, formed of a succession of distinct and contiguous river valleys, open onto gulfs (Porto, Liscia, Prunelli, Gravona, Taravo) and resting on imposing reliefs to the north-east and to the east. These parcels, sheltered by the reliefs and benefiting from the best exposures, present soils of granitic grus, rich in silica, alumina, potash and sometimes calcium. These situations confer on the geographical area an edapho-climatic complex that offers to all of the vineyard of "Ajaccio" optimal conditions, and, more particularly, to the master of the place, the sciaccarello N variety, the "craquant" (crunchy one), its ecological niche of predilection and the optimal playing field permitting it to reach an ideal ripeness that guarantees the originality and the balance of the wines and that the producers will know how to exploit. These situations are expressed by the minerality, the aromatic richness and the finesse of the wines and the fine tannic seat of the red wines. The winegrowing community has known, over the generations, how to apprehend and value the hillsides formed by these different valleys, not hesitating to install the vineyard at altitude. Thus, contrary to the rest of the Corsican vineyard, the vineyard may sometimes appear dispersed. It is, in fact, only the expression of the know-how in the optimal use of the propitious territory. The poor soils impose an optimal management of the plant and of its production potential, reflected in the training of the vine, precise pruning rules and controlled yields. The know-how of the producers is also reflected in the capacity of the elaborator, by the choice of the blends of the wines arising from the different situations, to express the richness and the originality of the natural environment. On the western coast, the town where NAPOLEON was born appears in its ochres and its pinks of an old Genoese city. The producers maintain the notoriety and the reputation of the wines of "Ajaccio", thanks to their dynamism, their know-how, their attachment to a particular viticultural landscape and their historical attachment to the island varieties.

XI. – Transitional measures

The vine parcels in place at the date of 31 July 2009 and whose planting density is between 3,000 plants per hectare and 4,000 plants per hectare continue to benefit, for their harvest, from the right to the controlled designation of origin, until they are grubbed up.

XII. – Rules of presentation and labelling

Wines for which, under the terms of the present specification, the controlled designation of origin "Ajaccio" is claimed and which are presented under the said appellation may not be declared, after the harvest, offered to the public, dispatched, put up for sale or sold unless, in the harvest declaration, in advertisements, on leaflets, labels, invoices and any containers whatsoever, the aforesaid controlled designation of origin is entered.

CHAPTER II

I. – Declaration obligations

1. Declaration of renunciation to produce

Every operator declares to the defence and management body, before 1 June preceding the harvest, the parcel(s) for which it renounces to produce the controlled designation of origin. The defence and management body transmits this declaration to the approved control body as soon as possible.

2. Claim declaration

The claim declaration must be sent to the defence and management body within a minimum time limit of fifteen days before any movement of the wines between approved warehouse keepers and at the latest on 25 November of the year of harvest. The defence and management body will transmit a copy to the approved control body. It indicates: - the appellation claimed; - the volume of wine; - the EVV or SIRET number; - the name and address of the applicant; - the place of storage of the wine. It is accompanied by: - a copy of the harvest declaration, and, as the case may be, a copy of the production declaration or an extract of the stock accounts for the buyers of grapes and musts; - and the general plan of the places of storage, permitting in particular the number, the designation and the capacity of the containers to be identified.

3. Transaction declaration and declaration relating to the dispatch outside the national territory of a non-packaged wine

Every operator wishing to market in bulk a wine benefiting from the controlled designation of origin must make to the approved control body a transaction declaration at least eight working days before the first removal and within a maximum time limit of two working days after the transaction. Every operator wishing to carry out a dispatch outside the national territory of a non-packaged wine benefiting from the controlled designation of origin must make the declaration thereof to the approved control body at least eight working days before dispatch. The operator must specify the colour and the volumes concerned.

4. Prior declaration of packaging

Every operator wishing to package a wine of the controlled designation of origin must send to the approved control body a prior declaration of packaging at least three working days before the start of the packaging period. The operator must specify the colour and the volumes concerned.

5. Fallbacks (replis)

Every operator marketing a wine benefiting from the controlled designation of origin under a more general appellation must make the declaration thereof to the defence and management body and to the approved control body within a maximum time limit of eight working days after this fallback.

6. Downgrading declaration

Every operator carrying out a downgrading of wines benefiting from the controlled designation of origin must make the declaration thereof to the defence and management body and to the approved control body within a maximum time limit of eight working days after this downgrading.

II. – Keeping of registers

No particular provisions.

CHAPTER III

I. – Main points to be checked and evaluation methods

MAIN POINTS TO BE CHECKED	EVALUATION METHODS
A – STRUCTURAL RULES	
A1 – Belonging of the planted parcels to the delimited area.	Documentary check.
A2 – Claimable production potential (grape varieties and proportion rules, monitoring of the transitional measures, planting density).	Documentary check and check in the field.
A3 – Processing, ageing, packaging and storage facility. — Global vat capacity.	Documentary check and on-site check.
Place of vinification.	On-site check.
Place of storage.	On-site check.
B – RULES LINKED TO THE PRODUCTION CYCLE	
B1 – Management of the vineyard. — Pruning.	Check in the field.
Average maximum load per parcel.	Check in the field.
Irrigation.	Documentary check and check in the field.
B2 – Harvest, transport and ripeness of the grapes. — Ripeness of the grapes.	Documentary check and check in the field.
B3 – Processing, elaboration, ageing, packaging, storage. — Oenological practices and physical treatments.	Documentary check and on-site check.
B4 – Harvest declaration and claim declaration. — Missing vines.	Documentary check (keeping of register) and check in the field.
Authorised yield.	Documentary check.
C – CHECKS ON THE PRODUCTS	
Before and/or after packaging or at the stage of placing on the market for the consumer.	Documentary check and analytical examination.
At the stage of the bulk removals or at the stage of placing on the market for the consumer.	Organoleptic examination.
Non-packaged wines intended for a dispatch outside the national territory.	Analytical and organoleptic examination of all the lots.

II. – References concerning the control structure

National Institute of Origin and Quality (INAO)
TSA 30003
93555 – MONTREUIL-SOUS-BOIS Cedex
Tel: (33) (0)1.73.30.38.00
Fax: (33) (0)1.73.30.38.04
Email: info@inao.gouv.fr

The check of compliance with the present specification is carried out by a third-party body offering guarantees of competence, impartiality and independence, under the authority of the INAO, on the basis of an approved inspection plan.

The inspection plan sets out the self-checks carried out by the operators on their own activity and the internal checks carried out under the responsibility of the defence and management body. It indicates the

external checks carried out by the third-party body as well as the analytical and organoleptic examinations. The whole of the checks is carried out by sampling. Non-packaged wines intended for a dispatch outside the national territory are the subject of a systematic analytical and organoleptic check.